RELIGION AND SUPERSTITION

THE HAZARDOUS AND UNPREDICTABLE nature of any seaman's life, subject to the vagaries of weather and waves, is compounded in naval service by the uncertainties of warfare creating fertile ground for superstition of all kinds. Religious belief at sea has in some of its aspects been hard to distinguish from superstition, although religion has often developed a very different role as a motivating and bonding force, and a source of spiritual comfort on board.



APOLLO Ancient Greek galley crews sang specific hymns, or paeans, to the god Apollo as they rowed into battle. Battlefield paeans were accompanied by pipes and instruments called *kitharas*, like the one Apollo is seen holding here.

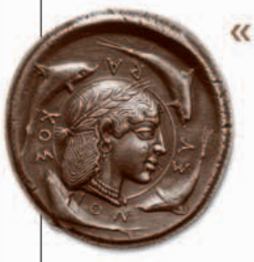
OMEN AND SACRIFICE

In ancient times any enterprise, whether in peace or war, would be preceded by animal sacrifice and the consultation of omens, often by examination of burned entrails. On important occasions renowned professionals were employed for the purpose, like Euphrantides the Soothsayer who allegedly advised Themistocles to sacrifice three Persian prisoners to the gods before the battle of Salamis. When Roman consul Publius Claudius infamously refused to heed the omen presented by sacred chickens before the defeat at Drepana, Rome was in uproar and it nearly cost him his life. The Viking warriors, worshipers of Odin and Thor, practiced human sacrifice and divination from examining the remains of the victims. Omens could also be accidental, however. At Lepanto a number of crows were seen over the Turkish fleet before the battle, and their admiral had great difficulty persuading his men to enter the fight.



SACRED CHICKENS Roman leaders would consult sacred chickens, specially brought on board for the purpose, for signs of divine support prior to battle. A chicken that refused to eat the grain it was offered could prove ominous.

> *Now Friday came. Your old wives say,*
> *Of all the week's the unluckiest day.*
>
> **RICHARD FLECKNOE,** Diarum (1656) on the belief preventing ships launching on Fridays.



SILVER COIN In deference to Charon, ferryman of the underworld in Greek legend who was paid with a coin, shipbuilders once placed a silver coin under the masthead.

EX-VOTO These works were a display of gratitude to God for sparing the mariner, fulfilling part of the deal they made with God in a time of difficulty. The painting by a Spanish sailor opposite depicts the moment of peril.



SUPERSTITIONS

Sailors maintained into modern times many beliefs that are widely though to be pagan in origin. For example, death was believed to come with the ebb tide. If a dying man survived one ebb tide, he would live until the next. Possessing a caul from a newborn baby was believed to ensure a man against drowning—sailors were still known to buy cauls into the 20th century. It was also unlucky to kill a seagull or, especially, an albatross, since they embodied the souls of lost mariners. This prohibition was not universally observed—sailors were known to make tobacco pouches out of albatrosses' webbed feet. It was bad luck to carry a corpse on board. If unavoidable, it should always be carried sideways onto the ship, not end on. Whistling was generally disapproved of as likely to cause a storm, although soft whistling might be indulged in a dead calm as a way of summoning a wind. Placing a silver coin under the mast might ensure good fortune, while it was taboo to launch a ship on a Friday.